Experts Ask the Government to Explain What 'Ultraprocessed' Food Means

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What makes a food "**ultraprocessed**"? Believe it or not, the U.S. government has never given an official answer. Now more than 100 science, medical and food experts want that to change.

On Friday, the experts signed an open letter to the Office of Management and Budget, urging the government to release its first-ever definition of **ultraprocessed** foods, called UPF for short. The letter said most Americans have heard of UPF and want to avoid them, but few people really understand them.

The effort began in July 2025. In August, health and agriculture officials sent a proposed definition for final review. The foods include sugary cereals, sodas, burgers and store-bought breads. According to media reports, food company bosses stepped in and slowed the release.

The term comes from the **NOVA system**, created in 2009 by researchers in Brazil. It sorts food into four levels by how much factory processing it goes through. **Ultraprocessed** foods are broken apart and rebuilt with added colors, flavors and **emulsifiers**, explained Lindsey Smith Taillie, a nutrition professor at the University of North Carolina, Chapel Hill.

Studies link eating lots of these foods to heart disease, **obesity** and **Type 2 diabetes**. The time for the public to comment on the definition ended on Friday.

Word Treasure

ultraprocessed -- Describes foods that are broken apart and rebuilt in factories with added colors, flavors and other ingredients.

emulsifiers -- Ingredients added to factory-made foods when they are broken apart and rebuilt.

NOVA system -- A way of sorting food into four levels by how much factory processing it goes through.

obesity -- Being very overweight in a way that can be bad for your health.

Type 2 diabetes -- An illness where the body has trouble controlling the sugar in the blood.

Background you need

Many foods in stores are made in factories, where they are changed a lot before they are packed and sold.

The most changed foods are called ultraprocessed: they are broken apart and rebuilt with added colors, flavors and emulsifiers.

Because eating lots of these foods is linked to health problems like heart disease and obesity, experts want one clear official definition so everyone knows exactly which foods count.

Break it down

WHO: More than 100 science, medical and food experts who signed an open letter
WHAT: They asked for the release of the first-ever official definition of ultraprocessed foods
WHERE: The letter went to the Office of Management and Budget in the U.S. government
WHY: Most Americans have heard of ultraprocessed foods and want to avoid them, but few people really understand what they are

Why it matters

Knowing which foods are ultraprocessed can help you and your family pick snacks and meals that keep your body healthy.

Test what you remember

1. What did more than 100 experts sign on Friday?

- (A) A new food label
- (B) A study about diabetes
- (C) An open letter
- (D) A proposed definition

2. Who was the letter sent to?

- (A) The Office of Management and Budget
- (B) Food company bosses
- (C) A nutrition professor
- (D) Researchers in Brazil

3. In this story, what is UPF short for?

- (A) Unprocessed fresh foods
- (B) Ultraprocessed foods
- (C) Universal processed foods
- (D) United Public Foods

4. Where was the NOVA system created?

- (A) Chapel Hill
- (B) The United States
- (C) France
- (D) Brazil

5. Which food does the story name as an ultraprocessed food?

- (A) Fresh apples
- (B) Plain rice
- (C) Garden salads
- (D) Sugary cereals

6. What health problems do studies link with eating lots of ultraprocessed foods?

- (A) Colds and flu
- (B) Bad eyesight
- (C) Heart disease, obesity and Type 2 diabetes
- (D) Broken bones and sprained ankles

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: B 4: D 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. The experts who signed the letter: They want the government to release its first definition of ultraprocessed foods, because most Americans have heard of them and want to avoid them, but few really understand them.

2. Food company bosses: According to media reports, they stepped in and slowed down the release of the proposed definition.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):